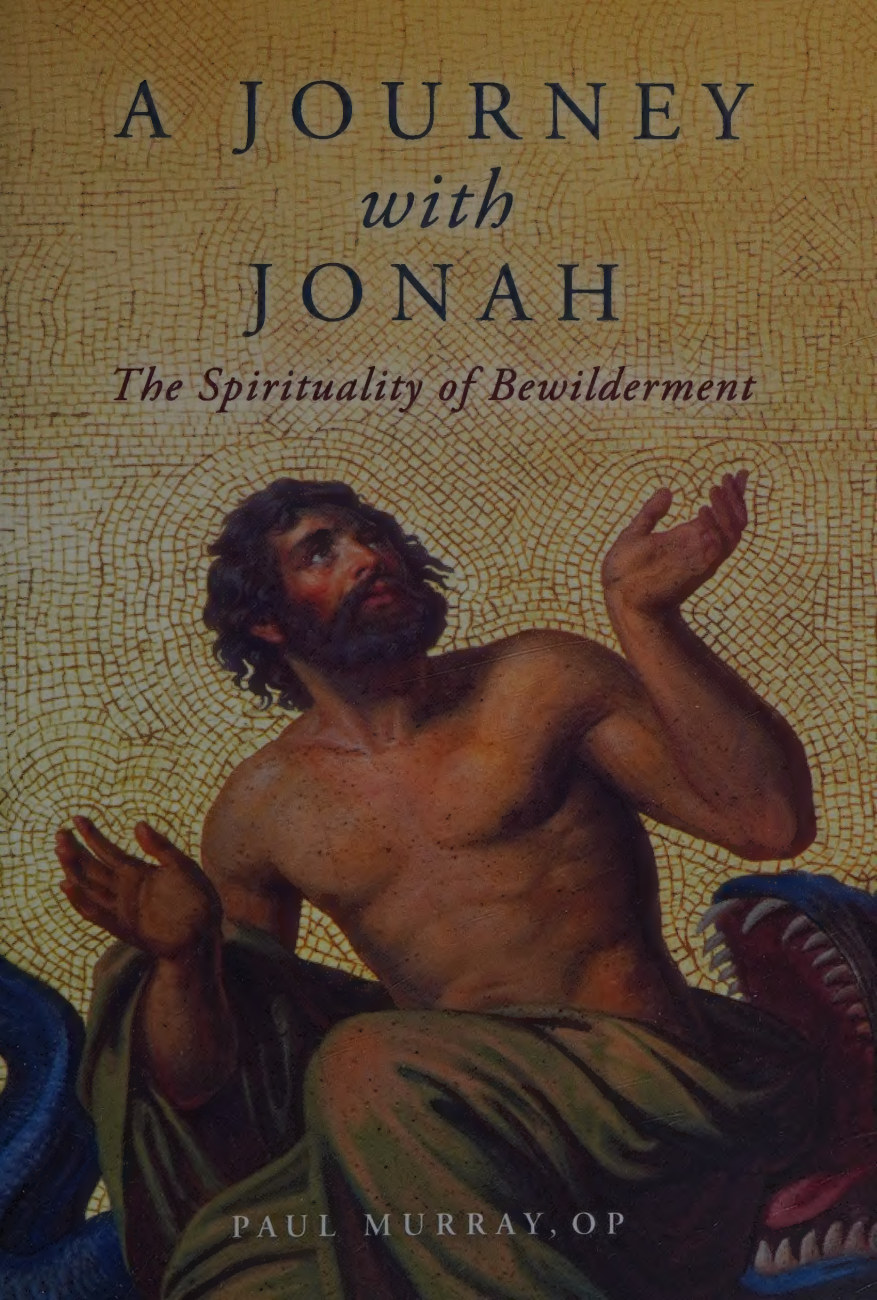
A JOURNEY *with* JONAH

The Spirituality of Bewilderment



PAUL MURRAY, OP

A JOURNEY *with* JONAH

"Can you write a lucid guide to bewilderment? Fr. Paul Murray has done so, explaining Jonah with a wide range of references, psychological and spiritual insight, and clarity."

—**Rabbi David Wolpe**, Max Webb Senior Rabbi

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—**Fr. Damian J. Ference**, Vicar for Evangelization in the Diocese of Cleveland, Assistant Professor of Philosophy at Borromeo Seminary

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To Sally Read

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INTRODUCTION

One clear indication of the importance of the book of Jonah is the fact that Jonah is the only ancient prophet with whom Jesus identifies himself in a dramatic way in the New Testament, and to whom he refers explicitly by name.[1] As soon, however, as we turn to read the book itself, with the thought of the book's importance in our minds, we find ourselves at once somewhat bewildered. For the so-called "book" turns out to be only two pages long; and Jonah, the prophet, a prophet of only one short sentence.

Even more surprising, Jonah is—sad to say—no hero. In fact, if anything, he's a sort of anti-hero.

1. There are, in fact, three references made to Jonah in the New Testament: Matt. 12:38–42; Matt. 16:1–4; and Luke 11:29–32. On each occasion, Jesus speaks about what he calls "the sign of Jonah." Jesus also refers to Elijah on a number of occasions but only when asked a question by his disciples, and he identifies Elijah with John the Baptist, not with himself.

Normally we think of prophets as men of character. But in this case, all that we can say of Jonah is that, in the Irish sense of the word, he's a *character*! I sometimes think the term "Gubu factor" might almost have been coined to describe the extraordinary happenings in the story of this minor prophet. You remember what "Gubu" stands for—G U B U: grotesque, unbelievable, bizarre, and unprecedented.[2] And, let's face it, the text of the book itself, with a cast of characters that includes thousands of animals in sackcloth and one great prophet-swallowing whale, might almost have been written, in another age, by the Irish comic genius Myles na gCopaleen!

All that being said, however, I am convinced that the book of Jonah is the most profoundly Christian of all the books in the Hebrew Bible, and the book from

2. These four words were used in a remarkable press conference given by the Irish politician Charles J. Haughey on August 16, 1982. According to one of Haughey's biographers, "The press took up these dramatic words in reports and headlines, and out of the initial letters Conor Cruise O'Brien . . . constructed the acronym and mnemonic GUBU." See Bruce Arnold, *Haughey: His Life and Unlucky Deeds* (London: HarperCollins, 1993), 201.

which we have the most to learn at the beginning of this new millennium. What is more, given the book's great subtlety and, at times, quite pungent satire, I am myself persuaded that it is probably the most "Irish" of all the books in the Bible!

But let's begin first with a brief outline of the story. The book opens with Jonah rejecting God's explicit command to preach to the Gentiles of Nineveh. In fact, Jonah runs away as far as possible in the opposite direction, boarding a ship bound for Tarshish. Soon, however, when a huge storm rises, the terrified men on the ship feel compelled to cast Jonah into the ocean. But, at that moment, a great fish—often pictured as a whale—swallows the astonished prophet.

Jonah remains inside the belly of the whale for three days, praying in his anguish, until he finds himself regurgitated onto land. Deciding, then, to obey God's command after all, he prophesies to the people of Nineveh the destruction of their city within forty days. The people of Nineveh repent, and God forgoes his threat of punishment against them. But this decision

deeply irritates Jonah. He is all of a sudden filled with self-pity and wants to die. His anger is further roused when a plant, which had afforded him temporary shelter against the scorching heat, is withered. But the end of the story, Jonah is brought to realize that God can show kindness to whom he will, no matter which race or nation the people belong to, and even if they are living within the evil city of Nineveh.

In outline, the story seems simple enough. In fact, the entire work consists of no more than forty-eight verses. And yet, around this small book, as if it were around Jonah's own troubled ship, high waves and storms of controversy have swirled for centuries. Vastly different currents of thought, represented by ancient rabbis and scholars, medieval and modern exegetes, contemporary believers and postmodern skeptics, have surrounded the work with questions concerning its date of composition, its authorship and literary genre, its basic theme and purpose. But so far, and perhaps not surprisingly, little or no consensus has been reached. In fact, at times, in terms of understanding, all we seem to have before us is what has

been called by one exegete "a tempest in a text."[3]

In some ways, the situation today is much as it was in the fourth century. At that time, St. Jerome, in his own commentary on the book, noted that although many Latin and Greek authors had already given their attention to the book of Jonah, "by their many questions they have not so much clarified as obscured the meaning, so much so in fact that their own interpretation needs itself to be interpreted, and the reader leaves more uncertain than he was before he began his reading."[4] Twelve centuries later, Martin Luther leveled a no less bitter complaint against St. Jerome himself.

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3. Phyllis Trible, "A Tempest in a Text: Ecological Soundings in the Book of Jonah," *Theology Digest* 43, no. 4 (1996): 303–312. On one key question, however, there is by now almost unanimous agreement among scholars—namely, that the author of the book of Jonah is not concerned with presenting a literal, historical account: "Recognition of the book's literary qualities has turned the attention of interpreters to the work's character and function as story" (see A.R. Ceresko, "Jonah," in *The Jerome Biblical Commentary*, ed. Raymond E. Brown, Joseph A. Fitzmyer, and Roland E. Murphy [Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall, 1990], 580).

4. Jerome, prologue to *In Jonam prophetam*, in Patrologia Latina, ed. J.-P. Migne, vol. 25 (Paris, 1845), col. 1117–1118 (all translations of this text are my own).

Along with certain other Fathers of the Church, Jerome had obscured the text of Jonah, Luther claimed, with "intricate, innumerable, and silly questions," although the text itself is "clear, easy to understand, and full of comfort."[5]

In my own opinion, some of the best commentaries on the book of Jonah have not come from the scientific minds of exegetes, but from poems and paintings, sculpture, stained glass, and children's stories and plays. These kinds of "readings," when one work of art or one "construct of the imagination" responds to another—and responds from *within* the creative act or the creative process itself—are often, in George Steiner's opinion, "of a penetrative authority rarely equaled by those offered from outside, by those propounded by the non-creator, that is to say the reviewer, the critic, the academic."[6]

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5. "Lecture on Jonah: The Latin Text, 1525," in *Luther's Works*, vol. 19, ed. H.C. Oswald, trans. Charles D. Froehlich (St. Louis: Concordia, 1974), 4–5.

6. George Steiner, *Real Presences* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989), 12. For a reflection on some of the many different images of Jonah in art and literature, see James Limburg, "Jonah and

Undoubtedly, one of the most brilliant responses ever made to the book of Jonah is Herman Melville's *Moby-Dick* and, in particular, the famous sermon delivered, in chapter nine, by the sailors' chaplain, Father Mapple. "Shipmates," the priest explains, "this book [the book of Jonah] . . . is one of the smallest strands in the mighty cable of the Scriptures. Yet what depths of the soul does Jonah's deep sea-line sound! what a pregnant lesson to us is this prophet!"[7]

My intention here, in these pages, is to try to uncover something of "the pregnant lesson" of the prophet Jonah. But as well as focusing attention on the text itself, I hope to take some soundings within the depths of the Jewish and Christian soul, to explore, that is, something of the impact Jonah has made over the centuries on the Judeo-Christian tradition. But also, however briefly, I would like to note examples

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the Whale through the eyes of Artists," *Bible Review* 6, no. 4 (August 1990): 18–25. See also Yvonne Sherwood, *A Biblical Text and its Afterlives: The Survival of Jonah in Western Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000).

7. Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale*, 2nd ed. (New York: W.W. Norton, 2002), 49.

of the response that the Jonah story has awakened in a number of creative writers, poets, and artists, both inside and outside the Judeo-Christian tradition.

The message of the book of Jonah, its "pregnant lesson," can be divided into three parts. Accordingly, the present study will be structured in a simple threefold manner under the following headings:

1. Obedience to the Word: The Lesson of the Wild Storm
2. In the Belly of Paradox: The Lesson of the Great Whale
3. Compassion without Limit: The Lesson of the Wondrous Plant

Chapter 1

Obedience to the Word: The Lesson of the Wild Storm

"Arise, go to Nineveh" (1:2 RSV-CE). These are words addressed uniquely to Jonah, requiring obedience. But over the centuries, Jewish and Christian commentators, preachers, and poets have, on occasion, extended the meaning of the text to include all of us in some sense, for all of us—if not now, sooner or later—are called to go and face some "Nineveh" of our own. There is a claim on us—on our time, on our love, on our courage—that we would rather avoid. In one of his *Divine Poems*, the seventeenth-century poet Francis Quarles describes the challenge to go to "Nineveh" as a command, among other things, to do what justice demands. He writes:

> Jonah must go, nor is the charge confin'd
> To Jonah, but to all the World enjoyn'd:
> You magistrates, arise, and take delight
> In dealing Justice, and maintaining right:
> There lies your Nineveh; Merchants arise
> And mingle conscience with your Merchandise;
> Lawyers arise, make not your righteous Laws
> A trick for gain.[1]

For Quarles, all the different vocations and professions are under the Word, under the call of God, even if here, in his poem, only three are mentioned explicitly: magistrates, merchants, and lawyers.

There is an interesting twentieth-century short play by Wolf Mankowitz in which Jonah appears as a sort of traveling salesman "who has his eye out for a sharp bargain," but who finds himself all of a sudden called to be a prophet.[2] The call does not please this

1. Francis Quarles, "A Feast for Wormes: A Poeme of the History of Jonah," in *Complete Works in Prose and Verse*, vol. 2, ed. Alexander B. Grosart (Edinburgh: T. & A. Constable, 1880), 10.

2. Wolf Mankowitz, *It Should Happen to a Dog: A Play in One*

twentieth-century Jonah one little bit. He cries out at one point in the play: "You can't do this to me. I am on very important business."[3] And, in another place, he exclaims: "Please, please, what do you want from my life? . . . All these years I've been running—a traveller—Jonah, the traveller, representing Top Hat; Braces For The Trousers; Fair Lady Fancy Buttons; Hold Tight Hair Grips—only good brands in the suitcase. Ask them in Tarshish . . . I shouldn't have to run with a suitcase any more. And still he nags me. All right. I heard. I'm going."[4] To Jonah's profound irritation, the voice of God always comes to him in the form of birds chirping inside his head. "I hate birds," Jonah complains. And then: "You know what it says? 'Arise, Jonah, arise. Go to Nineveh, that great city, and cry against it.' I ask you. Why pick on me?"[5]

The humor in Mankowitz's play echoes the humor in the book of Jonah itself. But the message about obedience

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Act, in *Religious Drama* 3, ed. Marvin Halverson (Gloucester, MA: Peter Smith, 1972), 123.

3. Mankowitz, 129.
4. Mankowitz, 125.
5. Mankowitz, 126.

remains a serious one all the same. And it occurs to me that, perhaps in all of the literature about Jonah, no one keeps the seriousness of this message more to the forefront of his mind than Father Mapple in *Moby-Dick*: "As with all sinners among men," the priest declares, "the sin of this son of Amittai was in his willful disobedience of the command of God—never mind now what that command was, or how conveyed—which he found a hard command. But all the things that God would have us do are hard for us to do—remember that—and hence, he oftener commands us than endeavors to persuade. And if we obey God, we must disobey ourselves; and it is in this disobeying ourselves, wherein the hardness of obeying God consists."[6]

Father Mapple paints a vivid picture of Jonah skulking about the wharves of Joppa, hiding from God, and seeking "a ship that's bound for Tarshish":

> Miserable man! Oh! most contemptible and worthy of all scorn; with slouched hat and guilty eye,

6. Melville, *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale*, 2nd ed. (New York: W.W. Norton, 2002), 49.

> skulking from his God; prowling among the shipping like a vile burglar hastening to cross the seas. So disordered, self-condemning is his look, that had there been policemen in those days, Jonah, on the mere suspicion of something wrong, had been arrested ere he touched a deck. . . . In vain he tries to look all ease and confidence; in vain essays his wretched smile.[7]

Of course, in the end, Jonah does manage to get on board a ship. He goes down into the hold of the ship and is soon fast asleep. But then, all of a sudden, as if in imitation of the prophet's disobedience, "the sea rebels."[8] In Father Mapple's words: "A dreadful storm comes on, the ship is like to break. But now when the boatswain calls on all hands to lighten her; when boxes, bales, and jars are clattering overboard; when the wind is shrieking, and the men are yelling, and every plank thunders with trampling feet right over Jonah's head; in all this raging tumult, Jonah sleeps his hideous sleep."[9]

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7. Melville, 49–50.
8. Melville, 51.
9. Melville, 51.

The text of the book of Jonah itself reads: "Then the mariners were afraid, and each cried to his god. They threw the cargo that was in the ship into the sea, to lighten it for them. Jonah, meanwhile, had gone down into the hold of the ship and had lain down, and was fast asleep. The captain came and said to him, 'What are you doing sound asleep? Get up, call on your god! Perhaps the god will spare us a thought so that we do not perish'" (Jon. 1:6). The anguish of the captain brings to mind at once the anguished cries of the disciples of Jesus, in St. Mark's Gospel, during a comparable storm. In chapter four, we read: "A great windstorm arose, and the waves beat into the boat, so that the boat was already being swamped. But he was in the stern, asleep on the cushion; and they woke him up and said to him, 'Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing?'" (Mark 4:37–38). Almost like a new Jonah, Jesus would seem to have found himself here in the same situation as the bewildered son of Amittai. But, in spite of the marked similarities between these two incidents, there exists of course an enormous gap between the state of mind of Jesus and that of our unhappy prophet.

St. Jerome, commenting on this particular passage—and wanting Jonah to be a hero, not a coward—attributes Jonah's sleep to what he calls "the serenity of the soul of the prophet."[10] Jerome asserts that Jonah is calm even in the face of imminent shipwreck, since "neither tempest nor dangers disturb him."[11] The suggestion, though greatly complimentary to the prophet, is clearly untenable. And even St. Jerome appears to change his mind within the space of a paragraph, openly acknowledging the fact that Jonah knows very well that the tempest is actually "raging against him." *That*, Jerome says, is the real reason why Jonah goes down into the hold of the ship and seeks oblivion in sleep. So intense are his feelings of sadness and guilt, he simply cannot bear, it seems, the pain of staying awake.

Reflecting on this particular stage in the story, Father Mapple draws a sharp comparison between Jonah's condition and that of an unhappy drunkard: "Like one who after a night of drunken revelry hies to his bed, still reeling, but with conscience yet pricking

10. Jerome, *In Jonam prophetam*, col. 1125.
11. Jerome, col. 1125.

him. . . . At last, amid the whirl of woe [which he is feeling], a deep stupor steals over him, as over the man who bleeds to death, for conscience is the wound, and there's naught to staunch it; so, after sore wrestling in his berth, Jonah's prodigy of ponderous misery drags him drowning down to sleep."[12]

The understandable but desperate strategy of sinking down, as far as possible, into the stupor of sleep is, of course, simply a way of refusing to hear the voice of God, refusing to obey. I think it is no accident of grammar that our English word "disobedience" comes from the Latin *obaudire* (to listen), and so *dis*-obedience means, literally, "not to listen." Jonah's impulse to avoid responsibility and evade the command of God by hiding himself away in the womb of sleep has inevitably attracted the attention of many modern psychologists. For them the story of Jonah is "not only a religious manifesto; it is also a psychological tableau of the human condition."[13] The "Jonah" in *us*, we are

12. Melville, *Moby-Dick*, 51.

13. See André Lacoque and Pierre-Emmanuel Lacoque, *Jonah: A Psycho-Religious Approach to the Prophet* (Columbia: University of

told, desires somehow to regress into the warm, protective womb of the mother. In his book *The Forgotten Language*, Erich Fromm suggests that the images of "going into the ship, going into the ship's belly, falling asleep, being in the ocean and being in the fish's belly" are all "symbols" that stand for "a condition of being protected and isolated, of safe withdrawal from communication with other human beings."[14]

This solipsistic tendency on the part of Jonah—what psychologists refer to as "the Jonah-and-the-Whale complex" or "the Jonah syndrome"—is, we are asked to believe, a tendency that forms part of the "Jonah" make-up within all of us. I have no doubt that there is wisdom in this theory.[15] But what interests me here is not so much the psychological manifestations of this tendency but rather the complex form that it has assumed today in contemporary spirituality. As all

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South Carolina Press, 1990), 217.

14. Erich Fromm, *The Forgotten Language* (New York: Rinehart, 1951), 22.

15. Carl Gustav Jung was the first to use the term "Jonah-and-the-Whale complex." See Jung, *Symbols of Transformation*, trans., R.F.C. Hull (New York: Pantheon, 1956), 419.

of us are well aware by now, there is a new fascination among our contemporaries with the things of the spirit. Unfortunately, however, that interest doesn't always translate into a capacity to attend to the living voice of God or to surrender with faith and hope and love to the transcendent beauty and pressure of divine revelation. Instead, there is a tendency to live one's spirituality within the bubble of the self, and practice what Martin Buber has called, in a memorable phrase, "the religion of pure psychic immanence."[16]

Modern consciousness, Buber writes, looks to the soul as the *only* sphere in which we can expect to harbor or discover the "divine."[17] And this marks, of course, a complete shift away from transcendence to immanence. In Buber's opinion, "[Modern consciousness] will have nothing more to do with the God believed in by the religions, who is to be sure present to the soul, who reveals Himself to it, communicates with it, but

16. Martin Buber, *Eclipse of God: Studies in the Relation between Religion and Philosophy*, trans Maurice S. Friedman et al. (New York: Harper & Brothers, 1957), 84.

17. Buber, 83.

remains transcendent to it in His being."[18] A spirituality of this kind—an exclusively *immanent* spirituality—at least in its extreme manifestations, represents a regress back to a safe, controlled environment, a "return to the womb." In terms of religion, it is nothing less than a spiritual manifestation of "the Jonah syndrome."

But let us turn our attention back once more to the text itself: "Jonah, meanwhile, had gone down into the hold of the ship and had lain down, and was fast asleep. The captain came and said to him, 'What are you doing sound asleep? Get up, call on your god! Perhaps the god will spare us a thought so that we do not perish'" (Jon. 1:5–6). A moment ago, I attempted, in a not-too-complimentary fashion, to relate Jonah's sleep to certain forms of contemporary spirituality. But thinking further about Jonah's sleep, I cannot escape the thought that the thrust and challenge of this text relate, whether we like it or not, to those among us who consider ourselves members of Christ's Church, and in particular to those of us who feel called to be preachers of the Word. For, like Jonah, we have been given a task

18. Buber, 83.

to complete and a message to preach to the world—but are we preaching it? Are we not, perhaps, living in a kind of bubble ourselves?

"The church today is in retreat." This bald, simple statement was included in a sermon about Jonah, which was preached at Westminster Chapel, London, some years ago. But it is a sermon that could, I think, be preached again today. The Church, though entrusted with the Word of truth is, we are told, like Jonah, because it "has looked to Tarshish and not Nineveh. The church is like Jonah who paid the fare to sail on the ship going in the opposite direction from what God demanded. The church has spent its energy, its time and its money on the wrong things. The church at the present time is like Jonah, asleep in the sides of the ship while the world is tossed in unprecedented bewilderment. The world is afraid—the church is asleep. The world asks questions—the church has no answers."[19]

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19. R.T. Kendall, *Jonah: Sermons Preached at Westminster Chapel* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1978), 11.

When, finally, Jonah emerges on deck, he finds himself forced to admit that he is the cause of all the trouble and that he should, therefore, be thrown overboard at once. "I know it is because of me," he says to the sailors, "that this great storm has come upon you" (Jon. 1:12). In a lengthy Latin poem, "Carmen de Iona Propheta," which for centuries has been attributed to Tertullian, Jonah is heard to exclaim—and the phrase I think is remarkable—"In me is the storm. I am all the madness of the world" (*Ego tempestas, ego tota insania mundi*).[20] In the next verse of the poem, Jonah is heard to cry out: "'Tis in me . . . / That the sea rises, and the upper air / Down rushes; land in me is far, death near, / And hope in God is none!"[21]

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20. Tertullian, "Carmen de Iona propheta," in *Quae Supersunt Omnia*, vol. 2, ed. Francis Oehler (Leipzig: T.O. Weigel, 1854), 770 (my translation).

21. "A Strain of Jonah the Prophet" ["Carmen de Iona propheta"], trans. Sydney Thelwall, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 4, *The Fathers of the Third Century*, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson, and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885), 128. Martin Luther, in his commentary on *Jonah*, notes that "a much greater storm was raging in Jonah's heart and conscience than raged on the sea outside" ("Lecture on Jonah: The Latin Text," 10).

In spite of Jonah's despair, the sailors, according to the book of Jonah, try their best to control the storm. They make a last, desperate effort to get Jonah and themselves safely back to land. But the sea becomes ever more turbulent. The reality of Jonah's disobedience has to be faced, and the consequences accepted. The sailors take up Jonah in their arms and throw him into the deep.

One early Christian author, who identified himself, in a particular way, with this moment in the life of Jonah, was an Irish saint. His name, in its original form, meant "dove." And that, as it happens, is also the meaning in Hebrew of the name "Jonah." The saint in question is none other than the remarkable Abbot of Luxeuil and Bobbio, St. Columban. In 610, Columban found himself expelled from Burgandy after he had spoken out against the wild sexual mores and pagan lifestyle of Theodoric II. In 613, writing in a letter to Pope Boniface IV, Columban dares to compare himself with Jonah since, just a few years earlier, with the threat of expulsion hanging over his head, he had come very near to experiencing the "shipwreck" of all his

hopes.[22] On another occasion, finding himself in the midst of an ecclesial storm that had been brewing for many years, Columban wrote to one particular group of bishops who were involved in the controversy, and who were decidedly opposed to his way of thinking and acting: "If on my account this storm is upon you, take me and cast me into the sea, that this tempest may recede from you in calm; yet let it first be your part, like those mariners [in the book of Jonah], to seek to save the shipwrecked by the bowels of godliness, and to draw the ship to land."[23]

In Letter IV—undoubtedly the most moving of all the letters of Columban—the famous abbot writes to his own religious brethren and asks his "frugal brothers" to pray for his safety.[24] Referring to himself as a "sinful dove" (*colomba peccator*), he draws their attention to the great drama and vulnerability of his present situation by suggesting an identification with

22. "Letter V," no. 16, in *Sancti Columbani Opera*, ed. and trans. G.S.M. Walker (Dublin: Dublin Institute for Advanced Studies, 1997), 55.

23. "Letter II," no. 7, 19.

24. "Letter IV," no. 1, 27.

the prophet Jonah at the moment of his expulsion into the deep.[25] He writes: "If I am cast into the sea like Jonah, who himself is also called Columba in Hebrew, pray that someone, a safe concealor, may take the place of the blessed whale, and by rowing, restore me, your Jonah, to the land he longs for."[26] The passage, though brief, is so distinctive in its expression and so poignant in its meaning that it impresses me as nothing less than a sharp, bright jewel in St. Columban's writing. Nevertheless, the episode of the whale as the saint remembers it here is, to say the least, somewhat glamorized, and the whale itself practically canonized! For what actually awaits the prophet Jonah after he finds himself cast out

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25. "Letter IV," no. 1, 27.

26. "Letter IV," no. 8. The image of the whale appears again in a story concerning another famous Irish saint, also called Columba, or sometimes Columcille. In an early biography of the saint, in one section, we read of "how the saint spoke with foreknowledge concerning a great whale." Apparently, a brother in the community, named Berach, when he was about to set out on a journey by boat, was told by St. Columba that he would confront on the open sea "a prodigious monster." And, in fact, Berach and his sailors did see "a whale, of marvellous and enormous size, swimming on the surface," and "it rose up like a mountain, and opened gaping jaws, with many teeth." See *Adomnan's Life of Columba*, ed. and trans. A.O. Anderson and M.O. Anderson (London: Thomas Nelson & Sons, 1961), 245–247.

of the boat by the sailors is—as we will discover in a moment—by no means an easeful trip home!

Chapter 2

In the Belly of Paradox: The Lesson of the Great Whale

"For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the whale, so will the Son of man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth" (Matt. 12:40 RSV-CE). In this passage, Jesus compares himself to Jonah, and he refers explicitly to a "whale." The book of Jonah itself, however, speaks only of "a large fish": "The Lord provided a large fish to swallow up Jonah; and Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights" (Jon. 1:17). It is a short statement, laconic almost to a fault, but it has captured the imagination of countless generations of believers, both Jewish and Christian. Here is a passage, for example, from a Jewish work of the ninth century concerning Jonah and the fish. It is a prose work, but

at times it reads almost like a poem: "Rabbi Tarphon said: 'That fish was specially appointed from the six days of Creation to swallow up Jonah. . . . He entered its mouth just as a man enters the great synagogue, and he stood (therein). The two eyes of the fish were like windows of glass giving light to Jonah.'"[1]

The idea of a light somehow illuminating the insides of the fish was also put forward by another rabbi in the same text, but the form of light suggested was something entirely different: "Rabbi Meir said: 'One pearl was suspended inside the belly of the fish, and it gave illumination to Jonah, and it showed to Jonah all that was in the sea, and in the depths.'"[2]

I think it's worth noting here that, in the literature of the ancient world (whether in the form of myth or story), the image of an enormous fish—a primeval sea monster—occurs over and over again. And what is more, the possibility of such a creature existing

1. *Pirkê de Rabbi Eliezer: The Chapters of Rabbi Eliezer the Great*, trans. Gerald Friedlander (New York: Sepher-Hermon, 1971), 69.
2. *Pirkê de Rabbi Eliezer*, 69–70.

has continued to fascinate people even up to modern times. Leonardi da Vinci, for example, while engaged in developing a theory about the growth of the earth, and pondering in particular the significance of certain bones that he thought might have belonged to a primeval sea creature, suddenly turned upside down the page on which he was working, and addressed the putative, god-like creature in these words: "O how often were you seen amid the waves of the vast and swollen ocean, like a mountain defeating and subduing them, and your black and bristly back plowing through the waters, and your stately, solemn bearing!"[3]

Among the Christian commentators on Jonah, one of the most interesting and original is Martin Luther. Here, with characteristic verve, is Luther pondering the mystery of Jonah's experience inside the whale: "It must have seemed an interminably long time that he sat there in the dark. Yes, I suppose that he occasionally lay down and stood up. . . . How often lung and liver must

3. Folio 265 of the *Codex Atlanticus*, quoted in Italo Calvino, *Six Memos for the Next Millennium*, trans. Geoffrey Brock (Boston: Mariner Books, 2016), 98.

have pained him! How strange his abode must have been among the intestines and the huge ribs!"[4] Jonah's mysterious suffering inside the whale, and his sudden, unexpected release three days later, comprise a story, an image, that is referred to and reflected on over and over again by many of the great Christian commentators. St. Augustine of Hippo, for example, toward the end of his life, remarked: "Jonah prophesied Christ rather in suffering than in speaking, and that most manifestly in regard to the Passion and Resurrection. For why was he three days in the whale's belly and then let out, but to signify Christ's resurrection from the depth of hell on the third day?"[5]

Although there are a number of texts written by the early Church Fathers on the subject of Christ as the new Jonah, it was not on parchment but on stone—in

4. Martin Luther, "Lecture on Jonah: The German Text, 1526," in *Luther's Works*, vol. 19, ed. H.C. Oswald, trans. Charles D. Froehlich (St. Louis: Concordia, 1974), 68. Worth comparing and contrasting with Luther's imaginative rendering of the text is the playful but sardonic commentary by Voltaire on the brief, unhappy sojourn of the prophet inside the whale's belly. See Voltaire, "Les questions de Zapata" (1767), in *Mélanges* (Paris: Librairie Gallimard, 1961), 960.

5. St. Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, 18.30, in *Corpus Christianorum*, vol. 48 (Turnhout, BE: Brepols, 1955), 621 (my translation).

colored fresco, in fact—that we find the first extended Christian testimony or presentation of Jonah as the image of Christ. Those pilgrims or tourists who have had the opportunity to visit the catacombs in Rome will no doubt have been surprised at how often the early Christians painted the image of Jonah on the walls. Louis Réau, in his work *Iconographie de l'Art Chrétien*, goes so far as to suggest that the image of Jonah arriving safely on shore after being ejected by the whale is "the essential image" for the early Christians.[6] And why? Because it is an image that reveals, with great vividness, the hope of a sure resurrection and the promise of life eternal to the many Christian men and women undergoing persecution at the time.

Jonah's exit from the whale—in the tradition of early Christian art in Ireland—was also understood as a symbol of the Resurrection and was represented in both bronze and stone. One of the most interesting examples is the Irish crozier-head found at Aghadoe (Kerry). The stem of the crozier curves at the top and

6. Louis Réau, *Iconographie de l'art Chrétien*, vol. 2-1, *Ancien Testament* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1956), 417.

becomes a small Jonah valiantly making his exit from the open jaws of the whale, "dressed like an acrobat in a tight-fitting jersey."[7]

Jonah's whale also makes a somewhat dramatic appearance in at least one of the mystery plays—*sacre rappresentazioni*—which were produced annually by a company of young tradesmen attached to the Dominican Priory of San Marco in Renaissance Florence. Documents in the Magliabechi collection of the National Library in Florence indicate that the young company spent almost all of its income on the stage properties and costumes they thought necessary for each individual performance. The treasurer of the company, in 1449, was more than a little irritated, it would seem, when, for one particular performance, an enormous amount of money was spent on a great whale made out of paper and wickerwork and decorated all over with gold stars. In the play, which was performed on the Feast of the Purification, Jonah, taking his turn with the other prophets from the Hebrew Bible,

7. See Françoise Henry, *Irish Art in the Romanesque Period: 1020–1170 A.D.* (London: Methuen, 1970), 114; pl. 85, fig. 9. For examples of stone carvings of Jonah in Ireland, see 128, 130, 147, and 156 in this same work.

was summoned forward by an angel to declare his foreknowledge of Christ, the Son of God. Emerging, then, we may presume, from the belly of the great paper-whale itself, Jonah exclaimed:

> Three days I remained in that sea-fish,
> A symbol of forgiveness of sins,
> for that's how long Christ remained in his tomb
> and then triumphed with his human nature.[8]

Before God commands the fish to spew his captive out onto the shore, Jonah, we are told, from inside the belly of the great fish, prays "to the Lord his God" (Jon. 2:2). The prayer or psalm is an impressive canticle of praise. But it is also deeply moving in the way it reveals the terror and distress of the stricken prophet.

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8. See *Rappresentazione della Purificazione*, vol. 2, in *Nuovo Corpus di Sacre Rappresentazioni Fiorentine del Quattrocento*, ed. Nerida Newbigin, 177–180 (Bologna: Commissione per i Testi di Lingua, 1983), 95. See also Nerida Newbigin, "The *Rappresentazioni* of Mysteries and Miracles in Fifteenth-Century Florence," in *Christianity and the Renaissance: Image and Religious Imagination in the Quattrocento*, ed. T. Verdon and J. Henderson (Syracuse, NY: Syracuse University Press, 1990), 361–375.

The waters closed in over me;
the deep surrounded me;
weeds were wrapped around my head
at the roots of the mountains.
I went down to the land
whose bars closed upon me forever.
(Jon. 2:5–6)

It is not difficult to imagine how both Jewish and Christian communities, undergoing great persecution, would at once identify with the hope and anguish of the drowning Jonah. An anonymous poet from the Jewish tradition, for example, a poet of no pretension whatever, wrote these stark few lines:

Jonah prayed to the Lord:
And to Him I appeal in my trouble;
To the Lord I plead from Sheol's belly,
You hear my voice.
I gaze upon your holy shrine.
You raise me from the grave alive.[9]

9. The original Hebrew text is published in Peter Schäfer, *Synopse zur Hekhalot-Literatur* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 1981), 144–

Jonah's going down into the depths of the ocean has been understood as a descent into death, a descent into the very pit of hell itself. Again, no one, I think, has ever described this journey better than Herman Melville. The passage I have in mind is again taken from the sermon of Father Mapple:

> God came upon him in the whale, and swallowed him down to the living gulfs of doom, and with swift slantings tore him along "into the midst of the seas," where the eddying depths sucked him ten thousand fathoms down, and "the weeds were wrapped about his head," and all the watery world of woe bowled over him. Yet even then beyond the reach of any plummet—"out of the belly of hell"—when the whale grounded upon the ocean's utmost bones, even then, God heard the engulphed, repenting prophet when he cried. Then God spake unto the fish; and from the shuddering cold and blackness of the sea, the whale came breeching up towards the warm and pleasant sun, and all the

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145, quoted in Jack Sasson, *Jonah* (New York: Doubleday, 1990), 215.

> delights of air and earth; and "vomited out Jonah upon the dry land."[10]

That last image of Jonah being "vomited out upon the dry land" caught the attention of quite a number of well-known writers and poets in the twentieth century. Hart Crane, for example, in a tongue-in-cheek poem entitled "After Jonah," recounts how, out of the "snare" of the whale's belly, the poor prophet was "belched back like a word to grace us all."[11]

Thomas Merton, the American Trappist monk, also composed a poem on the subject. It's a great poem, I think, but it's not a pious poem. And maybe that's the reason why, during Merton's own lifetime, it was never included in any of his many published collections of poems. The work, entitled "All the Way Down," evokes rather vividly the image of the prophet. But the voice Merton lends to Jonah, or rather lends to what one

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10. Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale*, 2nd ed. (New York: W.W. Norton, 2002), 53.

11. Hart Crane, "After Jonah," in *Modern Poems on the Bible: An Anthology*, ed. David Curzon (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1994), 336.

might call the Jonah within himself, is that of a brilliant, uncontainable, feisty and exuberant, self-willed and cantankerous monk!

All The Way Down
(Jonas Ch. 2)

I went down
Into the cavern
All the way down
To the bottom of the sea.
I went down lower
Than Jonas and the whale.
No one ever got so far down
As me.

I went down lower
Than any diamond mine
Deeper than the lowest hole
In Kimberly
All the way down
I thought I was the devil

He was no deeper down
Than me.

And when they thought
That I was gone forever
That I was all the way
In hell
I got right back into my body
And came back out
And rang my bell.

No matter how
They try to harm me now
No matter where
They lay me in the grave
No matter what injustices they do
I've seen the root
Of all that believe.

I've seen the room
Where life and death are made
And I have known
The secret forge of war

I even saw the womb
That all things come from
For I got down so far!

But when they thought
That I was gone forever
That I was all the way
In hell
I got right back into my body
And came back out
And rang my bell.[12]

Most Christian commentary on the book of Jonah has been concerned to draw out certain points of comparison between Jonah's experience and the life, death, and Resurrection of Christ. But on occasion, the drama of Jonah's life has been regarded simply as an image — albeit a rather heightened image—of what life is like for all of us in this world. John Jewel, the Anglican bishop of Salisbury, for example, writing toward the end of the sixteenth century, draws the reader's attention, first

12. Thomas Merton, *The Collected Poems of Thomas Merton* (New York: New Directions, 1977), 669–670.

of all, to the paradoxical nature of Jonah's experience inside the whale's belly: "The place was very dark: the waves beat on every side: he was drowned yet touched no water; he was swallowed up, yet not consumed. . . . The tempest was death, yet he died not, but lived in the midst of death; he could not see, he could not hear, he knew not to whom he might call for help."[13] Then, Bishop Jewel adds: "Let us mark well this story: it is a true pattern of our estate, and sheweth what our life is in this world."[14]

In a similar vein, the third-century martyr and bishop Methodius, in a fragment on Jonah, states that "the ship in which [Jonah] embarked, and which was tempest-tossed, is this brief and hard life in the present time. . . . And the storm and the tempests which beat against us are the temptations of this life. . . . And being swallowed by the whale signifies our inevitable removal by time. For the belly in which Jonah, when he was swallowed, was concealed, is the all-receiving

13. John Jewel, *A Treatise of the Holy Scriptures* (1570), quoted in Sasson, *Jonah*, 65.

14. Sasson, *Jonah*, 65.

earth, which receives all things which are consumed by time."[15]

But what of the *Christian* experience? What of life in Christ? As believers can we not expect to enjoy the security, the serenity, of faith? Are we not protected from "the thousand natural shocks that flesh is heir to," and from the storms of fate? We *are* protected, I would say, and we are *not* protected. Life in Christ—true religion—does not take the cross out of our lives. It does not render us immune to great suffering or misfortune. And yet, no matter how relentless or terrible the storm might appear, because Christ himself is at the heart of the storm and because as our Redeemer he lives in us and we in him, we have no reason to be afraid.

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15. Methodius, "On the History of Jonah," in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 6, *The Fathers of the Third Century*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1886), 378. For yet another reflection in this vein, see the ancient Jewish text called *The Zohar*, in which a certain Rabbi Abba remarks that "in the story of Jonah we have a representation of the whole of a man's career in this world. . . . Man, then, is in this world as in a ship that is traversing the great ocean and is like to be broken" (quoted in James Limburg, *Jonah: A Commentary* [Louisville, KY: Westminster / John Knox, 1993], 108.

Here I think it is necessary to make a distinction between what John Macmurray has called illusory religion and real religion: "The maxim of illusory religion runs: 'Fear not; trust in God and He will see that none of the things you fear will happen to you'; that of real religion, on the contrary, is 'Fear not; the things that you are afraid of are quite likely to happen to you, but they are nothing to be afraid of.'"[16]

Of course, it is also true, thank God, that we are given wonderful gifts in this life, gifts of family and friendship, of individual talents and vocation, gifts of adventure and discovery, of places to visit and revisit, and gifts of happiness and success in our work. But not all of us—it has to be said—are blessed with these gifts. And none of us can hold on to them forever. For whether we are rich or poor, believers or nonbelievers, busy business executives or contemplative religious, whether we are young or old, handsome or ugly, weak or strong, life in this world—given its suddenness and

16. John Macmurray, *Persons in Relation* (London: Faber & Faber, 1970), 171.

mystery, its beauty and horror, its puzzle, uncertainty, and risk—*is* a bewilderment.[17]

One of the things I admire about Thomas Merton is that he faced this truth head on. And it was to Jonah that he looked in order to express the paradox and bewilderment of his own life, his own vocation. Merton felt that his life as a monk, in particular, had been sealed with the sign of Jonah, that this sign had been somehow burned into the roots of his being. And why? Because he found himself, as he puts it, "traveling toward [his] destiny in the belly of a paradox."[18] Like Jonah, he had been ordered to go to his own Nineveh. But Merton admits: "I found myself with an almost uncontrollable desire to go in the opposite direction. God pointed one way and all my 'ideals' pointed in the

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17. Cardinal Newman, although utterly convinced of the existence of God, writes in *Apologia Pro Vita Sua*, of the "heart-piercing, reason-bewildering fact" of the apparent absence of God in the drama of human history. "I look out of myself into the world of men," he writes, "and there I see a sight that fills me with unspeakable distress. The world seems simply to give the lie to that great truth, of which my whole being is so full" ([Oxford: Clarendon, 1967], 216–217).

18. Thomas Merton, *The Sign of Jonas* (New York: Harcourt Brace, 1953), 11.

other."[19] But then Merton adds: "It was when Jonas was traveling as fast as he could away from Nineveh, toward Tharsis, that he was thrown overboard, and swallowed by a whale who took him where God wanted him to go."[20]

So the moment of actual failure and breakdown—the experience of bewilderment in our lives—can be the moment of *breakthrough*, the moment when God's grace finally shakes down all our defenses. And then, to our amazement, from out of the belly of failure, from out of the death of false dreams and false ideals and even from the jaws of a living hell, we can begin to experience the grace of resurrection.

For a certain number of Christian contemplatives, this experience of the dark night of transformation assumes a truly dramatic form. The Spanish mystic St. John of the Cross, for example, speaks of it as nothing less than a kind of "divinization."[21] Clearly, for him,

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19. Merton, 10.
20. Merton, 10–11.
21. See *The Dark Night*, 2.6, in *The Collected Works of St. John of*

something far more profound than a simple moral change or conversion is involved. He writes: "The soul . . . feels that it is melting away and being undone by a cruel spiritual death; it feels as if it were being swallowed by a beast and being digested in the dark belly, and it suffers an anguish comparable to Jonas's when in the belly of the whale."[22] But then John concludes: "It is fitting that the soul be in this sepulcher of dark death in order that it attain the spiritual resurrection for which it hopes."[23] God's intention, throughout this process, John explains, is not in any way to punish the soul: "The hand of God does not press down or weigh upon the soul, but only touches it; and this mercifully, for God's aim is to grant it favors and not chastise it."[24]

To conclude this second chapter of the book, I would like to draw attention to a poem or a hymn read first by Father Mapple in *Moby-Dick*. It is voiced

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the Cross, trans. Kieran Kavanaugh and Otilio Rodriguez (Washington, DC: ICS, 1973), 337.

22. John of the Cross, 2.6, 337.
23. John of the Cross, 2.6, 337.
24. John of the Cross, 2.6, 337.

for Jonah. But I think at some level or in some way, it speaks for all of us:

The ribs and terrors in the whale,
Arched over me a dismal gloom,
While all God's sun-lit waves rolled by,
And left me deepening down to doom.

I saw the opening maw of hell,
With endless pains and sorrows there;
Which none but they that feel can tell—
Oh, I was plunging to despair.

In black distress, I called my God,
When I could scarce believe him mine,
He bowed his ear to my complaints—
No more the whale did me confine.

With speed he flew to my relief,
As on a radiant dolphin borne;
Awful, yet bright, as lightening shone
The face of my Deliverer God.

My song forever shall record
That terrible, that joyful hour;
I give the glory to my God,
His all the mercy and the power.[25]

25. Melville, *Moby-Dick*, 46–47.

Chapter 3

Compassion without Limit: The Lesson of the Wondrous Plant

After three days in the belly of the whale, Jonah is belched out onto dry land. But the story does not end there. "The word of the Lord came to Jonah a second time, saying, "Get up, go to Nineveh, that great city, and proclaim to it the message that I tell you" (Jon. 3:1–2). This time, Jonah obeys. According to the description of our hero by Father Mapple in *Moby-Dick*: "Jonah, bruised and beaten—his ears, like two sea-shells, still multitudinously murmuring of the ocean," set out for the great city.[1]

1. Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale*, 2nd ed. (New York: W.W. Norton, 2002), 53.

In all the whirligig of events that follow (an extraordinary drama in which our hero fails once more to emerge in an impressive light) there is one incident, one stunning image of beauty and repose, that is worth noting: the incident of the plant. Jonah, in a mood of depression and self-pity, has sought out a refuge from the heat of the day. According to the biblical text, "The Lord God appointed a bush, and made it come up over Jonah, to give shade over his head, to save him from his discomfort; so Jonah was very happy about the bush" (Jon. 4:6).[2]

The image of Jonah the prophet, stretched out, blissful under his plant, has often been represented in Christian art, and also in the art of Islam.[3] For

2. Scholars believe that the word translated here as "bush" possibly refers to the castor bean plant.

3. Jonah (or Yūnus) is the only one of the major and minor prophets who is cited by his own name in the Quran. Muhammad does not hesitate, in fact, to number him among the apostles of God. See "Yūnus, the prophet Jonah," in *Shorter Encyclopaedia of Islam*, ed. H.A.R. Gibb and J.H. Kramers (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1974), 645–646. See also "Jonah in Islam," in James Limburg, *Jonah: A Commentary* (Louisville, KY: Westminster / John Knox, 1993), 113–118.

as powerfully and convincingly as any other image, it has offered, or has seemed to offer to believers, a glimpse of the true ease of self that would be theirs in the kingdom of God. In Jonah's case, however, the moment of bliss is short-lived. At dawn the next day, by God's command, Jonah's wondrous plant is attacked by a worm and withers. Jonah is furious. But God says to Jonah: "Is it right for you to be angry about the bush?" And Jonah answered: "Yes, angry enough to die" (Jon. 4:9).

Jonah's rage against God, when he realizes that his plant is ruined, has been depicted, on occasion, by Jewish artists over the centuries. But Christian painters and sculptors have, for some reason, shown a marked reluctance to paint or sculpt the anger of the prophet. There is, however, one striking exception. On the great wall of the Sistine Chapel, Jonah is represented as a young man in a state of sudden and uncontainable fury. He is shown seated alongside his withered plant, and he is by far the largest figure in the chapel. In fact, so dynamic and so enormous is the painted image of

the prophet that it can be said to dominate *The Last Judgment* fresco of Michelangelo.[4]

Reading through the book of Jonah, we soon come to realize that God speaks to us not only through his word but also through our own confused emotions. Jonah's relationship with God, at least to some significant degree, consists of a series of different states of feeling, all of which have been provoked by different circumstances: emotions of guilt, fear, joy, etc.

We might expect that the nearer God comes to an individual man or woman, the more that person would experience a kind of sustained bliss, or at least some kind of intense emotional rapture. But such "glorious bewilderment" is not, in fact, all that common in the

4. When it was first seen, the great fresco of Jonah occasioned awe among Michelangelo's contemporary artists. Vasari expressed the view of many when he wrote: "Who will not admire and remain astonished upon seeing the magnificence [*la terribilità*] of Jonah, the last figure in the chapel?" (Giorgio Vasari, *The Lives of the Artists*, trans. Julia Conaway Bondanella and Peter Bondanella [New York: Oxford World's Classics, 1991], 449).

Christian life. It is true that St. Teresa of Avila—and with her, a considerable number of other saints and mystics—refer on occasion to a stage in prayer in which the soul is so bewildered by the joy of love it hardly knows what to say or do. "It cannot tell," Teresa writes, "whether to speak or be silent, whether to laugh or weep. It is a glorious bewilderment, a heavenly madness, in which true wisdom is acquired, and to the soul a fulfillment most full of delight."[5] But such a state of rapture, if it occurs at all, occurs generally at a very advanced stage in the spiritual life.

What happens, in contrast, in the early or beginning stages, is that the warmth of God's love, being so close, stirs up in our hearts all kinds of buried hurts and resentments and weaknesses. St. John of the Cross, Teresa's fellow Carmelite and mystic, explains: "All the soul's infirmities are brought to light; they are set before its eyes to be felt and healed. Now with the light and heat of the divine fire, it sees and feels those weaknesses and miseries which previously resided within it, hidden

5. *The Life of St. Teresa of Avila by Herself*, trans. J.M. Cohen (London: Penguin Books, 1957), 112.

and unfelt."[6] In practice, therefore, at least in the early stages, instead of beaming with a newfound spirituality, we very quickly begin to appear like a damp log of wood that has been placed in a fire. Before we ourselves can catch fire with love, we begin first, according to John of the Cross, to "sweat and smoke and sputter."[7]

Often, in fact, it is in the midst of our emotional and passionate lives, rather than on some exalted spiritual sphere, that God speaks to us, and speaks with great authority. This surprising truth—this Jonah truth—is expressed not only in the work of St. John of the Cross but also in the work of

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6. John of the Cross, *The Living Flame of Love*, in *The Collected Works of St. John of the Cross*, trans. Kieran Kavanaugh and Otilio Rodriguez (Washington, DC: ICS Publications, 1973), 587.

7. John of the Cross, 587. Worth noting here, in passing, is a moment of profound emotional distress and bewilderment in the life of St. John of the Cross. He had managed to escape from Toledo, where he had been imprisoned and tortured by his own brethren, only to find himself stranded in a place (Andalusia) where he was quite miserable. "I was swallowed by that whale," he exclaimed in a letter to a friend, "and cast up in this strange harbour." See "Letter to M. Catalina de Jesús, July 6, 1581," in *The Complete Works of Saint John of the Cross*, vol. 3, trans. E. Allison Peers (Wheathampstead, EN: Anthony Clarke, 1974), 241.

the eighteenth-century Jesuit author Jean-Pierre de Caussade. Addressing those among us whose notion of spirituality and spiritual perfection borders on the abstract and the otherworldly, he declares: "You seek perfection, and it lies in everything that happens to you. Your suffering, your actions, your impulses, are the mysteries under which God reveals himself to you. But he will never disclose himself in the shape of that exalted image to which you so vainly cling."[8]

Geoffrey T. Bull, commenting on the destruction of Jonah's wondrous plant, imagines God saying to Jonah in rhyme, or in a sort of rhyme: "When it happened, you went all to pieces. / You shouted me down with your crude exegesis."[9] The rhyme, of course, is somewhat forced, but the statement is not inaccurate. For there was something strange, from the beginning, about Jonah's way of thinking. After all, he was a chosen prophet of Yahweh. And yet, one moment, we see

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8. Jean-Pierre de Caussade, *The Sacrament of the Present Moment*, trans. Kitty Muggeridge (London: Fount, 1981), 35.

9. Geoffrey T. Bull, *The City and the Sign: An Interpretation of the Book of Jonah* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1970), 153.

him in disobedience, and the next moment, in despair. What was Jonah's problem? What was wrong with his "exegesis"?

As we begin to understand the message of the book of Jonah, one thing becomes clear: the prophet's disobedience and despair were merely symptoms of a deeper problem: Jonah, in fact, was a religious bigot. He was a man of strong will but of narrow intelligence, a staunchly religious man, who simply could not bear the idea that Yahweh might want to extend his kindness to people who were not members of his own religion, and especially if those people were living in great sin as were the people of Nineveh. So when Jonah received the command from Yahweh to preach "against the city," he realized, right from the beginning, that God's threat of punishment was not serious; or, rather, it *was* serious, but only in the sense of being the expression of a merciful will or desire to call all people to repent and seek forgiveness. The dilemma of Jonah, at this point in the story, finds very clear expression in Francis Quarles' seventeenth poem concerning the prophet. Quarles places on Jonah's lips these four revealing lines:

> I know my God is gentle, and enclinde
> To tender mercy, apt to change his minde
> Upon the least repentance: Then shall I
> Be deem'd as false, and shame my Prophesie.[10]

Three centuries later, Robert Frost wrote a poem—or, perhaps more accurately, a verse-drama—concerning Jonah entitled "A Masque of Mercy." Asked about the poem in an interview, Frost remarked: "I noticed that the first time in the world's history when mercy is entirely the subject is in Jonah. . . . Jonah is told to go and prophesy against the city—and he *knows* God will let him down. He can't trust God to be unmerciful. You can trust God to be anything but unmerciful. So he ran away and—and got into a whale. That's the point of that and nobody notices it. They miss it."[11]

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10. Francis Quarles, "A Feast for Wormes: A Poeme of the History of Jonah," in *Complete Works in Prose and Verse*, vol. 2, ed. Alexander B. Grosart (Edinburgh: T. & A. Constable, 1880), 10.

11. "Robert Frost," in *Writers at Work: The Paris Review Interviews,* ed. Kay Dick (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1968), 88. One of the protagonists, in Frost's verse-drama, says to Jonah: 'That book of yours in the Old Testament / Is the first place in literature, I think, / Where Mercy is explicitly the subject. / I say you should be proud of having beaten / The Gospels to it.' See "A Masque of Mercy,"

Frost's sharp and wry comment is, of course, entirely accurate. For what Jonah guessed from the start—and the idea irritated him deeply—was that Yahweh would probably choose, in the end, not to punish any of the people of Nineveh. And in that event, he, Jonah, the chosen prophet of doom, after all his preaching, would appear like a false prophet or a complete fool. So Jonah ran away from God, not because he was afraid of God nor because he objected to being a prophet as such, but because of a religious obsession, a mistaken belief about the exclusivity of his own faith, a prejudice, a "crude exegesis" to which he clung tenaciously.

The message of the book of Jonah is that God, the living God, is the God of all people and a God of compassion. In fact, in the opinion of Martin Luther, this tiny book is nothing less than "a wonderful sign of God's goodness to all the world."[12] "Notice," Luther writes, "the wonderful attractiveness of the Divine

in *The Poetry of Robert Frost*, ed. E.C. Lathem (New York: Henry Holt, 1975), 508.

12. Martin Luther, "Lecture on Jonah: The German Text, 1526," in *Luther's Works*, vol. 19, ed. H.C. Oswald, trans. Charles D. Froehlich (St. Louis: Concordia, 1974), 36.

Majesty, how He handled and played with foolish, angry Jonah. . . . This is the gentle, fatherly way to handle sinners. . . . Notice how He winks at, how He quarrels with, Jonah's grumbling so that Jonah might . . . stop being angry."[13] As for Jonah himself, Luther makes an observation about the man I have not seen elsewhere, and it is worth noting: Jonah, he writes, is "a queer and odd saint who is angry because of God's mercy for sinners, begrudging them all benefits and wishing them all evil. . . . And yet he is God's dear child. He chats so uninhibitedly with God as though he were not in the least afraid of Him—as indeed he is not; he confides in Him as in a father."[14]

The full text of the book of Jonah has been read, since ancient times, in Jewish communities across the world on the feast of Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement.[15] And in the Reform Synagogues of Great

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13. Luther, 28–29.

14. Luther, 92.

15. On Holy Saturday, in the Greek Orthodox liturgy, the entire book of Jonah is read. On the same day, in the Roman Catholic liturgy, chapter 3 of the book of Jonah was read until Vatican II.

Britain, after the close of the Torah service on that day, the following prayer is recited:

> Lord, you are revealed in the story of Jonah, and we relate its meaning to ourselves; for Nineveh is the repentant world, and we are Israel, its unwilling prophet. You have chosen us to know You and to love You, and this knowledge is our glory, and this love is our burden. . . . Such knowledge is too wonderful for us. By it you reveal our kinship to friend and foe, our duty to those who love us, and to those who hate us; our task in a world where everything and everyone is Your work. If we are not for others, we are not for Israel. It is for us to bring the prisoner freedom, to give the homeless refuge, and the starving food. It is for us to sow the seed of friendship on unfriendly soil, to reconcile enemies, and bring redemption to our oppressors. . . . Your command is beyond all calculation.[16]

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16. "Yom Kippur Afternoon Service," in *Forms of Prayer for Jewish Worship*, vol. 3, *Prayers for the High Holidays* (London: Reform Synagogues of Great Britain, 1985), 551.

The book of Jonah ends with a question. It is a question put to Jonah by God in response to the prophet's bitter complaint about the withering of his plant: "Then the LORD said, "You are concerned about the bush, for which you did not labor and which you did not grow; it came into being in a night and perished in a night. And should I not be concerned about Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also many animals?" (Jon. 4:10–11).

The question, finding no answer from Jonah, has—if I'm not mistaken—a strange and sudden impact on those of us who, up to now, have been following the story. For, in the absence of any further word from God, or from his prophet, and with, in fact, the immediate and complete disappearance of Jonah from the scene, it is as if the question put to Jonah about prejudice and compassion is now, all of a sudden, and with a quite remarkable force and authority, directed at ourselves, the readers. We are no longer simply spectators of the Jonah story, but active participants.

Each one of us must now respond to the challenge of God's Word, and to the direct call for forgiveness. Here, on the open page in front of us—in the utter silence after the question—we are being offered the surprising freedom and opportunity to write out for ourselves, as it were, the final paragraph of the book of Jonah.

But what of the prophet himself? We are told nothing at all, in the text, about Jonah's response to God's question. So what are we to make of this gap at the end, this mysterious silence? Does it indicate, perhaps, a sullen anger on the part of Jonah? Has the unhappy prophet sunk back again into a deep depression? Or has the extravagant kindness of God—the word of compassion—somehow finally silenced the voice of prejudice in the heart of Jonah? In all of the discussion surrounding this matter, over the centuries, I am glad to say a considerable number of commentators, both Jewish and Christian, suggest a positive ending. Thus, in a medieval Jewish homily, for example, we read: "At that very moment, [Jonah] fell flat on his face saying, 'Direct your world according to the attribute

of mercy, as it is written, *Mercy and forgiveness belong to the Lord our God.*"[17]

The book of Jonah has been called, accurately enough, a "parable of mercy."[18] It is a work that contains a deeply serious and important message. And yet there is a strain of comedy in the story, a use of burlesque and parody that cannot be ignored. For the work is also a masterpiece of irony, a satire even, in which, scene after scene, the harsh tribalism and religious prejudice of stiff-necked people like Jonah is directly challenged, and also gently mocked.[19] Take the scene on board ship, for example. While the storm is at its height, where is Jonah? He is down in the ship's hold, fast asleep. But meanwhile, up above on deck, "the mariners," we're told, "were afraid, and

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17. *Midrash Yona*, quoted in Jack Sasson, *Jonah* (New York: Doubleday, 1990), 320. The quotation in italics is from Daniel 9:9.

18. Introduction to Jonah, New American Bible, Vatican website, November 11, 2002, https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0839/__PTV.HTM.

19. I think that "the literalists of the imagination" among us today are also gently mocked by this text. For if we insist on reading it as literal history, we will soon begin to feel confused— to the point of irritation—by its strange mythic extravagance and playfulness.

each cried to his god" (Jon. 1:5). So while the prophet dozes, the sailors—all of them Gentiles, and all of them apparently from different religions—are trying to hold on deck a sort of ecumenical prayer service!

No less impressive, of course, is the behavior of the wicked citizens of Nineveh. After hearing only one sentence from the prophet, they repent—all of them. And they undertake a great fast, put on sackcloth, and begin to "cry mightily to God" (Jon. 3:8). The contrast between the Ninevites' spirit of obedience and the disobedience of the Israelite Jonah is further underlined by one sharp, comic detail. We're told that even the animals in Nineveh, all the countless thousands of them, as a sign of repentance, are covered with sackcloth!

I cannot resist drawing attention here, in parentheses, to a short text from the ancient *Midrash Jonah*. A certain Rabbi ben Chalafta, no doubt somewhat irritated by the implications of the above story, is quoted as saying that the Ninevites' repentance was, in fact, a complete fraud. He suggests—and the idea is almost as comic as it is outrageous—that the Ninevites practiced

a form of emotional blackmail on God. "What did they do?" he asks. "They placed calves inside their houses and their mothers outside, so that the calves cried and howled inside, and the cows outside. The people said to the Holy One, blessed be He! If you do not have mercy on us, we will not have mercy on these."[20] The imagination behind this unusual passage has at least one redeeming feature: God is understood as someone who could not bear to witness for a moment the torture and distress of suffering creatures. But for the rest, the passage is so willful and so bizarre, I sometimes wonder if, perhaps, it was written tongue-in-cheek by its author, and if it represents, therefore, in the light of the Jonah story, a kind of deliberate self-parody.

In the book of Jonah itself, by choosing to employ different types of humor, Jonah's author not only "delights his readers," as Hans Walter Wolff has observed, "but also makes it easier for them to perceive God's loving laughter over narrow-minded piety."[21] Clearly,

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20. See Auguste Wünsche, *Aus Israels Lehrhallen*, vol. 2 (Hildesheim: Georg Olms, 1967), quoted in Limburg, *Jonah*, 111.

21. Hans Walter Wolff, *Obediah and Jonah: A Commentary* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1986), 12.

therefore, the humor in the work is no ornament. In fact, one can say, it forms part of the book's core revelation. For what is at issue in Jonah, from start to finish, is the transcendent mystery of God's freedom and God's love. And after reading through the book of Jonah a number of times, one begins to sense that, at the heart of that freedom and that love, there is an unimaginable joy.

Of course, our own minds and hearts are more like Jonah's than we care to admit. And that is why, like Jonah, we need, in the spiritual life, to be shocked and shaken out of certain fixed ways of thinking and feeling. We need to begin to recognize God in places where we would never, perhaps, have suspected his presence before, and not only in the big city, or in the places of our enemies, but also in the many seemingly banal and bizarre circumstances of our lives.

But, to learn this lesson—really to learn it—we need, like Jonah, to undergo the grace and mystery of bewilderment. Of course, we need many other graces as well—for example, the grace to sit still, the grace

to meditate, and the grace and the energy to work for peace and to fight for justice. But sometimes, it is only in the midst of the "tempest," in the heart of a storm of circumstances that we can't control, that we come finally to realize something of the wonderful mystery of God, and realize also how far beyond anything we can imagine or hope for are his plans both for ourselves and for the entire world.

People who have never been bewildered in life, or in the spiritual life, are not likely to be in close or living contact with transcendent love. This truth is something that Jean-Pierre de Caussade understood very well. There is a short prayer in his most famous work, *Abandonment to Divine Providence*, which has always impressed me. It is a prayer that asks God somehow to initiate us into the strange, necessary knowledge of bewilderment — a prayer that is in complete harmony, therefore, with the wisdom of the book of Jonah. I can think of no better way of ending a meditation entitled *A Journey with Jonah: The Spirituality of Bewilderment* than by drawing attention now to this short prayer:

O Divine Love, conceal yourself, leap over our suffering, make us obedient! Arouse us and confuse us. Shatter all our illusions and plans so that we lose our way and see neither path nor light until we have found you.[22]

22. De Caussade, *Sacrament of the Present Moment*, 35.

Afterword

God Took Pity

Joseph Ratzinger

This *lectio divina* was given by Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger in the Roman Church of Santa Maria in Traspontina on January 24, 2003.[1]

Meditating on the Word

The book of Jonah is not narrating events that took place in a distant past; it is a parable. In the mirror of this parable-story, both the future and the present become visible. The present is explained over and over again to different generations, and it is only in the light of the future—ultimately in that light which comes from God—that the present can be understood and

1. Joseph Ratzinger, "Dio si impietosì," *30Giorni*, no. 2 (2003), http://www.30giorni.it/articoli_id_362_l1.htm. Translated from the Italian by Catherine Marcelin-Rice.

lived correctly. This parable is consequently a prophecy. It sheds God's light on time and thereby clarifies for us the direction we must take so that the present may unfold onto the future and not go to ruin. In this parable we may distinguish three circles.

1) The text announces to unbelieving Israel salvation for the pagans and, indeed, the fact that pagans will precede Israel in faith. The pagans' entry into faith in the one God, who revealed himself to Israel on Sinai and elsewhere, stands out clearly in two passages of this short book. The mariners (Jon. 1:4–16), who were usually considered to be cruel and far from God, are converted when they witness the calming of the storm. They recognize that Jonah's description of his God is true: he is the God of heaven who made the sea and the dry land. They recognize this God of heaven as the one true God who holds the universe in his hand. And they know that their recognition must become action: they have already made a sacrifice on board the ship and promise a new thanksgiving as soon as they reach their destination. What is important is that Jerusalem no longer appears as the only place in which sacrifices

to God can be made—his temple is everywhere. Yet another element is important in this tale: the mariners had shown themselves to be filled with compassion and respect for human life, and it was only on Jonah's insistence that they dared to throw him overboard, imploring forgiveness for this sacrilege as they did so. In the humanity of their response can be seen, as it were, a disposition for grace that made access to faith possible for them.

The second prophecy (Jon. 3:1–10), truly central for the salvation of pagans, we find in Nineveh's history. The Assyrians, whose capital was Nineveh, were the most brutal warrior people of the ancient East; Nineveh is described in chapter 3 of Nahum as a bloody city. We are thus given an idea of its "wickedness," whose infamy has "come up before" God (Jon. 1:2). The city is a symbol par excellence of the abomination of human sin, which accumulates in the urban agglomerations of the large cities. It is "paganism" in its densest form. The incredible happens: the city believes the prophet and believes that there is a God, the God par excellence and not only its own gods. It believes that there is a

judgment and does penance. Here the contrast with the self-confidence of Israel becomes extremely clear. Chapter 36 of Jeremiah tells us how Jeremiah had read to King Jehoiakim the scroll announcing God's punishments. The king remained seated on his throne and cut up the scroll bit by bit, throwing the pieces into the fire until in the end the whole of the scroll had been burned. However, the king of the wicked city of Nineveh got up from his throne, stripped himself of all his regal insignia, and sat like a penitent in the ashes. He then used his royal power solely in order to impose on everyone—human beings and animals alike—a complete fast, to recall them to repentance, to call on them to come down from their seats into the ashes. Those who came down are those who rose to God: God took pity on them and saved them. The pagans' salvation is the salvation of those who accept the coming down of God and come down from themselves. Salvation is based on repentance. Those who are full of themselves are barred from salvation.

Here we see, shining through the text, Christ's entire Gospel. In the book of Jonah, the Old and New

Testaments interpenetrate one another and reveal themselves to be one.

2) The book of Jonah proclaims to us the event of Jesus Christ—Jonah is a prefiguration of Jesus' coming. The Lord himself tells us this quite clearly in the Gospel. When asked by the Jews to give them a sign that reveals him openly as the Messiah, according to Matthew he answers, "No sign will be given . . . except the sign of the prophet Jonah. For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the sea monster, so for three days and three nights the Son of Man will be in the heart of the earth" (Matt. 12:39–40). Luke's version of Jesus' words is simpler: "This generation . . . asks for a sign, but no sign will be given to it except the sign of Jonah. For just as Jonah became a sign to the people of Nineveh, so the Son of Man will be to this generation" (Luke 11:29–30). We see two elements in both texts: the same Son of Man, Christ, the one sent by God, is the sign. The Paschal Mystery points to Jesus as the Son of Man; he is the sign in and through the Paschal Mystery.

This mystery of Jesus itself shines through clearly in the Old Testament account. The first chapter of the book of Jonah refers to a triple "going down" of the prophet: he goes down to the port of Joppa, he descends into the ship, and once on board he goes down into the hold of the ship. In Jonah's case, however, this triple descent is an attempt to run away from God. Jesus is the one who goes down for love, not in order to flee but to reach the Nineveh of the world: he goes down from his divinity into the poverty of the flesh, of being a human creature with all its wretchedness and suffering; he goes down in the simplicity of the carpenter's son and goes down into the night of the cross, finally even into the night of Sheol, the world of the dead. In so doing, he precedes us on the road of the descent, far from our false kingly glory. This is the way of repentance, which is a way toward our own truth: a way of conversion, a way that distances us from Adam's pride, from wanting to be God, toward the humility of Jesus who is God and who for us emptied himself of his glory (Phil. 2:1–10). Like Jonah, Jesus sleeps in the boat while the tempest rages. In a certain sense, in the experience of the cross, he lets himself be thrown into the sea and thereby calms the

storm. Rabbis have interpreted Jonah's words "Throw me into the sea" (Jon. 1:12) as a self-offering by the prophet who wanted thereby to save Israel: he was afraid in the face of the pagans' conversion and the rejection of faith by Israel, and it was for this reason—so they say—that he wanted to have himself thrown into the sea. The prophet saves to the extent that he puts himself in the place of others. Sacrifice saves. This rabbinical exegesis became truth in Jesus.

3) Jonah represents Jesus, but he also represents Israel in its resistance to God's universal mercy. The name Jonah means "dove." In Hosea 7:11, Ephraim is described as a dove, "silly and without sense." Jonah, in whom, on the one hand, the mystery of Jesus shows through, is, on the other hand, an incarnation of stubborn Israel that fears the salvation of the pagans and resists this salvation, insisting on the uniqueness of its predilection, which it does not want to share with anyone. Whereas Elijah was upset by his failure and for this reason wanted to flee from God and die, Jonah fears success: he is, from the outset, afraid that ultimately the judgment will not be delivered. He knows

God and knows that, in the end, grace always prevails over judgment. Yet he hopes for judgment rather than grace for the wicked inhabitants of Nineveh. He hopes that his preaching may be shown to be true through God's judgment and not through his mercy, which, as it were, might make his preaching seem superfluous. In this he is like the elder brother in Jesus' parable of the prodigal son, which is in fact the parable of the two brothers. If the prodigal son is not punished and does not sink into the mire, my fidelity, thinks the elder brother, would be in vain, because a dissolute life would be better than fidelity—so it seems to him. A similar concept is found in Jonah; it is found in Israel's resistance to the entry of the pagans into the promise "apart from works prescribed by the law" (Rom. 3:28).

We must ask ourselves, as we go forward, what this means for us.

The Word illuminates our life and calls it into question

In history, the comparison between pagans who have become believers and faithless Israel soon became a

cause of misunderstandings that we must note and combat in every generation, since in the Church today we have become "Israel" and run the same risk as Israel: the risk "of the egoism of salvation," the risk of looking down on Israel from on high and considering ourselves automatically to be right. Indeed, Paul said in his Letter to the Romans: "They were broken off because of their unbelief, but you stand only through faith. So do not become proud, but stand in awe. . . . Note then the kindness and the severity of God: severity toward those who have fallen, but God's kindness toward you, provided you continue in his kindness; otherwise you also will be cut off" (Rom. 11:20–22). We find two key words: "faith" and "continue in God's kindness." Do we truly believe? Not only in theory but in such a way that faith becomes the foundation of our life, in such a way that we leave our life in God's hands? Continuing in God means continuing in his kindness: this is the core of faith. Not fearing his kindness—not fearing that he might be too kind to others so that my faith would have no value; continuing in his kindness, sharing in it: this is the sign of faith. We always fall into the temptation of the elder brother or of the first

laborer: we believe that faith only has value if others have less. But do we think it is more beautiful to live in faithlessness and in its appearance of truth rather than to be in the Father's house? Is faith a burden to us that we continue to carry but that, basically, we would like to be rid of? Or do we recognize that the seeming freedom of infidelity leaves life empty, whereas to stay with God is something beautiful? We are real believers only if we find joy in God and in his company and, by virtue of this joy, desire to pass on his kindness.

If these thoughts of the universality of divine mercy and of God's turning ever anew toward the pagans are conceived superficially, they can become a pretext for relativism and for indifference. We might say, "Salvation is grace in any event—we cannot deserve it. Being a pagan and being a Christian is the same thing; indeed, perhaps it's better to be a pagan, since pagans are not penetrated by the righteousness that comes from good works and self-importance, and can thus more easily receive grace as grace." Hence, there would not even be any sense in preaching the God of the Bible, the God of Jesus Christ. We would be inclined

to say, "Let us allow pagans to remain pagans; without doubt God will have mercy on them." And we would ourselves feel encouraged to be pagans, asserting, "If I sin, I am closer to grace; I will not so easily fall into the trap of being full of myself." A look at the text of Jonah, as at the whole Bible and especially the New Testament, shows how false and superficial all this is. Pagans, too, can feel full of themselves and comfortable with sin. Ultimately, the heart becomes blind, no longer desires God, no longer desires grace, no longer knows any repentance. But what is evil remains evil. Their wickedness had come up before God, the book of Jonah tells us, and God decided to intervene, for what is wicked must be overcome. The crimes of Hitler, of Stalin, of Pol Pot, and of many others, as well as of their accomplices and supporters, are crimes that bring the world to destruction and block the way to God. No, God's double invitation to Jonah, "Go at once. . . . Get up" (Jon. 1:2, 3:1), was not a sham but a compelling command whose fulfillment God was imposing despite the prophet's resistance. And Christ did not come because everything was already good and under the regime of grace, but rather because the call to goodness

and to repentance is absolutely necessary. The book of Jonah and its continuation in the New Testament is the most powerful denial of relativism and indifference imaginable. The words "Get up . . . and proclaim . . . the message that I tell you" (Jon. 3:2) also apply to today's Christians. Today, too, the one God must be proclaimed, the God who made the heavens, the dry land, and the sea, who reigns over history. Today, too, men and women need Christ, the true Jonah. Today, too, there must be repentance if there is to be salvation. And just as Jonah's way was for him a way of repentance, and its credibility stemmed from the fact that he had been marked by the night of suffering, so today, too, if we are to be credible, we Christians must be the first on the path to repentance.

The key words of our text are also applicable today and above all for us: conversion—"All shall turn from their evil ways" (Jon. 3:8)—and repentance. These words themselves are not used expressly, but the proclamation "Forty days more, and Nineveh shall be overthrown!" (Jon. 3:4) contains the symbolism of the forty days that indicates Israel's wanderings in

the desert and brings with it a concrete image of the theme of repentance. Here the key message of the New Testament shines through, which Jesus expresses in the words "Repent, and believe in the good news" (Mark 1:15). Each one of us must reflect what "conversion" means to him or her. The experience of the great converts in the Church's history was that the "yes" to Christ and to his Church—that is, Baptism—entailed first and foremost a completely new start; it radically changed their lives. But if they had thought that at this point everything had been done and was forever new, they must have realized from experience that the road of conversion must be followed and traveled again daily. This is precisely the difference between Israel's certainty of having been chosen and the Church *ex gentibus* (of the Gentiles): conversion is not beautiful and complete; it is never finished. God's image in you must be formed gradually; transformation into Christ, "putting on Christ," must happen gradually. Day after day I must combat my laziness and the habits that enslave me; prejudices regarding my neighbor, the likes and dislikes by which I let myself be swayed, the search for power and self-satisfaction, despondency and

resignation; I must combat cowardice and conformism as well as aggressiveness and bullying. Day after day I must come down off my throne and seek to learn the way of Jesus. Day after day I must empty myself of my certainties and overcome, in faith, my prejudices; I must not decide myself what it means to be Christian but learn from the Church and let myself be led by her. Day after day I must support others, just as they support me, given that God supports us all.

The book of Jonah is a theocentric book. The true actor in it is God. For, yes, God is still active—he does not withdraw from history (see John 5:17). And God loves creation. He cares for both human beings and animals. He is a God who combats what is wicked and for this reason must also punish, as judge, in order to do justice. This aspect of judgment, of punishment, of God's "anger," must not disappear from our faith. A God who accepts all things is not the God of the Bible, but rather a dreamed-up image. Jesus shows himself as the Son of God precisely because he can take the whip and angrily drive out the sellers from the temple. The very fact that God is not indifferent to what is evil gives

us confidence. However, that God's mercy is boundless remains true. We must always fight against sin and not lose the courage to do so, especially today. The way of easy sales talk is of no use. For it is only through the courage of the truth, which knows how to say no, that we serve goodness. This courage is fostered by our awareness of God's mercy, of the fact that he loves his creatures; he loves us. In the struggle against the evil in and around us we cannot give up; rather, let us fight this battle in the awareness that God is always "greater than our hearts" (1 John 3:20). Let us fight the battle with infinite trust and out of love, since we want to be close to the one we love and who first loved us (1 John 4:19). The better we learn to know God, the better we can say with Old Testament wisdom: "The joy of the LORD is your strength" (Neh. 8:10).

THE BOOK OF JONAH

Jonah Tries to Run Away from God

1 Now the word of the Lord came to Jonah son of Amittai, saying, [2] "Go at once to Nineveh, that great city,
and cry out against it; for their wickedness has come up
before me." [3] But Jonah set out to flee to Tarshish from
the presence of the LORD. He went down to Joppa and
found a ship going to Tarshish; so he paid his fare and
went on board, to go with them to Tarshish, away from
the presence of the LORD.

[4] But the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea,
and such a mighty storm came upon the sea that the
ship threatened to break up. [5] Then the mariners were
afraid, and each cried to his god. They threw the cargo
that was in the ship into the sea, to lighten it for them.
Jonah, meanwhile, had gone down into the hold of
the ship and had lain down, and was fast asleep. [6] The
captain came and said to him, "What are you doing

sound asleep? Get up, call on your god! Perhaps the god
will spare us a thought so that we do not perish."

7 The sailors said to one another, "Come, let us cast
lots, so that we may know on whose account this ca-
lamity has come upon us." So they cast lots, and the lot
fell on Jonah. 8 Then they said to him, "Tell us why this
calamity has come upon us. What is your occupation?
Where do you come from? What is your country? And
of what people are you?" 9 "I am a Hebrew," he replied.
"I worship the Lord, the God of heaven, who made
the sea and the dry land." 10 Then the men were even
more afraid, and said to him, "What is this that you
have done!" For the men knew that he was fleeing from
the presence of the Lord, because he had told them so.

11 Then they said to him, "What shall we do to you,
that the sea may quiet down for us?" For the sea was
growing more and more tempestuous. 12 He said to
them, "Pick me up and throw me into the sea; then the
sea will quiet down for you; for I know it is because of
me that this great storm has come upon you." 13 Nev-
ertheless the men rowed hard to bring the ship back

to land, but they could not, for the sea grew more and
more stormy against them. [14] Then they cried out to the
Lord, "Please, O Lord, we pray, do not let us perish
on account of this man's life. Do not make us guilty
of innocent blood; for you, O Lord, have done as it
pleased you." [15] So they picked Jonah up and threw him
into the sea; and the sea ceased from its raging. [16] Then
the men feared the Lord even more, and they offered a
sacrifice to the Lord and made vows.

[17] But the Lord provided a large fish to swallow up
Jonah; and Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days
and three nights.

A Psalm of Thanksgiving

2 Then Jonah prayed to the Lord his God from the
belly of the fish, [2] saying,

"I called to the Lord out of my distress,
and he answered me;
out of the belly of Sheol I cried,
and you heard my voice.
[3] You cast me into the deep,

into the heart of the seas,
and the flood surrounded me;
all your waves and your billows
passed over me.
4 Then I said, 'I am driven away
from your sight;
how shall I look again
upon your holy temple?'
5 The waters closed in over me;
the deep surrounded me;
weeds were wrapped around my head
6 at the roots of the mountains.
I went down to the land
whose bars closed upon me forever;
yet you brought up my life from the Pit,
O Lord my God.
7 As my life was ebbing away,
I remembered the Lord;
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
8 Those who worship vain idols
forsake their true loyalty.
9 But I with the voice of thanksgiving
will sacrifice to you;
what I have vowed I will pay.

Deliverance belongs to the Lord!"
[10] Then the Lord spoke to the fish, and it spewed
Jonah out upon the dry land.

Conversion of Nineveh

3 The word of the Lord came to Jonah a second time,
saying, [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, that great city, and
proclaim to it the message that I tell you." [3] So Jonah
set out and went to Nineveh, according to the word
of the Lord. Now Nineveh was an exceedingly large
city, a three days' walk across. [4] Jonah began to go into
the city, going a day's walk. And he cried out, "Forty
days more, and Nineveh shall be overthrown!" [5] And
the people of Nineveh believed God; they proclaimed
a fast, and everyone, great and small, put on sackcloth.

[6] When the news reached the king of Nineveh, he
rose from his throne, removed his robe, covered himself
with sackcloth, and sat in ashes. [7] Then he had a proc-
lamation made in Nineveh: "By the decree of the king
and his nobles: No human being or animal, no herd or
flock, shall taste anything. They shall not feed, nor shall

they drink water. [8] Human beings and animals shall be covered with sackcloth, and they shall cry mightily to God. All shall turn from their evil ways and from the violence that is in their hands. [9] Who knows? God may relent and change his mind; he may turn from his fierce anger, so that we do not perish."

[10] When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil ways, God changed his mind about the calamity that he had said he would bring upon them; and he did not do it.

Jonah's Anger

4 But this was very displeasing to Jonah, and he became angry. [2] He prayed to the Lord and said, "O Lord! Is not this what I said while I was still in my own country? That is why I fled to Tarshish at the beginning; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love, and ready to relent from punishing. [3] And now, O Lord, please take my life from me, for it is better for me to die than to live." [4] And the Lord said, "Is it

right for you to be angry?" [5] Then Jonah went out of the city and sat down east of the city, and made a booth for himself there. He sat under it in the shade, waiting to see what would become of the city.

[6] The Lord God appointed a bush, and made it come up over Jonah, to give shade over his head, to save him from his discomfort; so Jonah was very happy about the bush. [7] But when dawn came up the next day, God appointed a worm that attacked the bush, so that it withered. [8] When the sun rose, God prepared a sultry east wind, and the sun beat down on the head of Jonah so that he was faint and asked that he might die. He said, "It is better for me to die than to live."

Jonah is Reproved

[9] But God said to Jonah, "Is it right for you to be angry about the bush?" And he said, "Yes, angry enough to die." [10] Then the Lord said, "You are concerned about the bush, for which you did not labor and which you did not grow; it came into being in a night and perished in a night. [11] And should I not be concerned about

Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also many animals?"

"Fr. Paul Murray's compelling meditations on the book of Jonah bring to life the depth, beauty, and humor of this extraordinary and brief sacred text. Drawing on an amazing diversity of sources, Murray opens to the reader a stunning array of theological, psychological, and spiritual insights that Jonah has provoked throughout the centuries in authors and artists from Jewish, Christian, and Muslim traditions. Far more than a biblical commentary, *A Journey with Jonah* is a spiritually colorful and visceral exploration of the human flight from God's severe mercy—a mercy that ultimately triumphs in Jesus Christ."

—Tom Neal, Professor of Spiritual Theology, Notre Dame Seminary

Jonah is the only ancient prophet with whom Jesus identifies in the Gospels. But when we turn to read the book of Jonah itself, we discover that this so-called "book" is only two pages long—and that Jonah's prophesying is limited to one short sentence. And yet, around this small book, as if it were around Jonah's own troubled ship, high waves of controversy and mystery have swirled for centuries.

In *A Journey with Jonah: The Spirituality of Bewilderment*, Fr. Paul Murray strives to uncover the great lesson of this story. Following Fr. Murray's exploration is a 2003 *lectio divina* on Jonah by then-Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger—published here in English for the first time.

Paul Murray, OP, an Irish Dominican friar, lives in Rome where he teaches courses at the Angelicum University on the literature of the Western mystical tradition. He is a Fellow of the Word on Fire Institute and has published many books, including *Saint Catherine of Siena: Mystic of Fire, Preacher of Freedom*; *Scars: Essays, Poems, and Meditations on Affliction*; and *Aquinas at Prayer: The Bible, Mysticism, and Poetry*.

COVER ART: Carl Mayer, fresco of the prophet Jonah, nineteenth c., Altderchenfeld Church, Vienna.

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